

MOBACKSTAGEFINALEEDIT1

Travel Radio Australia, Travel Radio World. We're here in Amsterdam and we're at a very special place called Backstage with Mo Garzu, the brand manager. And this is a hair, makeup center for all of Europe's entertainers and people who are into professional hair and makeup.

Mo, welcome to the program. Hey Jeff, hello everyone. Thank you so much for having me today.

I'm really very excited to introduce Backstage to you, your community and all the people in Australia. And thank you so much for the opportunity. Well, it's wonderful to be here and we're sitting in, I would describe it as a television makeup studio, which you have a number of these in the store and we're in the beautiful Jordaan area of Amsterdam, the best area of Amsterdam.

And you have entertainers coming from Amsterdam, the Netherlands and all over Europe to be here. Tell us about the store. Like you said, we go back in time.

We've been in the industry for almost 35 years now. Backstage is a monumental hub in Amsterdam, especially when it comes to everything related to art, creativity, makeup, hair. We consider ourselves an inclusive service, an inclusive hub.

We welcome everyone. It's something we have been doing for almost four decades now. We are known for our professional take on the drag industry, the cross-dress industry.

We also have a retail store, like you said, in Amsterdam. And we carry plenty of professional makeup brands and hair brands. And we definitely have one very special department in our business, which is all about the medical hair.

We are, I believe, the only or one of the few businesses in Amsterdam and the Netherlands who offer this kind of service. We work with a lot of cancer patients. We have worked with hundreds of cancer patients.

We have created a lot of beautiful and meaningful bonds and connections with our clients. And this is where we, as you could feel, our service is very diverse. It's very inclusive.

We've got everything under one roof. And this is what makes us stand out in the market. And this is what creates an interesting narrative for Backstage in Amsterdam and the Netherlands.

I had the need for your service recently because I had some bruising on my face and I found that the makeup, I was just trying to find some concealer because I'm a professional magician as well as a journalist. And I found that the stuff you have here is fantastic for that. If you are injured or whatever, and you want to present yourself as not too scary, you can do that.

Now, we know you have some very famous people. We can't say who they are, but there's some very famous people like entertainers, drag queens, people who come in who need to look their

best. And tell us about some of those people who come in.

We won't mention any names, but they come in and they really love this place. As you know, based on your previous experience, Backstage is not just a shop. We have been working with plenty of celebrities, famous people, a lot of drag queens.

We go back in time with all of these people. I always call them the crème de la crème of our industry. They come to our store.

They know for a fact that Backstage is not just a shop. It's an experience. It's a hub.

And I'm sure you agree, based on your previous experience, it's way beyond just selling your product. It's all about consulting you. It's all about giving you an advice on a creative level.

We believe in our mission, which goes beyond just the product and selling products. And this is what makes it very interesting in terms of attracting these people and the crème de la crème to our store, because you can go on your laptop, you can order, you can make, it's a piece of cake. You can just click a button, you have your order delivered.

But what our celebrities and drag queens are interested in is the bond we have created with them, the way we make them feel special, the way they know that whatever they need, they will find at Backstage. And this is why I believe we have created somehow an interesting track record with these people. We look very forward to expanding this network and community and attract, hopefully, a bigger audience.

Now, one of your big markets is in October, the Halloween market. Now, you have people coming in here to really create something special for Halloween, and you've got all the bits and pieces to do that. Yeah, well, basically, we are quite known for this extravaganza kind of moments, especially that we have carried a lot of brands who are focusing on drag makeup, on artistic makeup, on special effects.

And this is what makes it the go-to place in Amsterdam. And for us, October and Halloween sounds like Christmas and the New Year. You lived in Amsterdam, you know the vibe in Amsterdam, and you know how people are always excited about those occasions and holidays.

And this is what makes it also exciting for us because whenever you come in, the house is always full, people are doing makeup, it's a creative vibe, the spirit is very festive, and there is a lot of craftsmanship. It's always one of our biggest months. What I also wanted to say was you must have, apart from the professional people, girls, women coming in and guys who really want to give a professional look to their makeup.

That is great too. You don't have to be a professional to come in here. You can just be someone off the street who wants to maybe get some great products or to improve their look.

Yeah, exactly. Our business is, as I said before, is inclusive. It's way beyond color, gender, ethnicity.

So for us, it's a platform where we cater for everyone. Whether you're a makeup lover, you have zero makeup skills, whether you're a professional in your industry as a makeup artist, as a celebrity, as a star, this is where I feel like you can relate to this experience. When you came in, you had a situation and we worked together on fixing the problem and we showed you through a couple of tricks and a couple of products, how we went from point A to point B to C. And this is where I look at you right now and I see you've done a great job.

You've done it yourself. So this is all about how we interact with our customers. It's about the advice.

It's about the attention. It's about the care and the love we show these people. And it's all about educating them.

So what you get from backstage is not just the product, it's the education, the information, the knowledge. And this is when we make sure we set you on the right track. We send you out and you come back to us and we hear, hey, how was it? Most of the time, it's just positive feedback.

So for me, it doesn't matter your background. It doesn't matter your skill level. Just come to us.

We'll take care of you. And we're gonna make sure we set you on the right track and the right path to at least start taking care of those little things that's causing a little bit of maybe an issue or insecurity. And I feel like this is the way to go.

We're chatting with Mo Garzoo. He's the brand manager here at Backstage Amsterdam, which is a fabulous professional place to come if you're into hair, makeup, costuming, all that sort of thing. Mo, you were saying before this, the events you have through the year are just fantastic here.

Absolutely. I mean, as you know, Amsterdam is a festival city. I've been living in Amsterdam for seven years now and I believe I've never witnessed anything like Amsterdam.

The city is always buzzing. People are always coming to Amsterdam to celebrate, to enjoy the freedom we have in Amsterdam. It's a free spirit, free vibe.

And for us, Backstage is quite part of this conversation. We've been here for 35 years. We've been part of the movement.

We had to shake things up. And we, I believe, based on my humble experience with Backstage, we have been the shake maker. We have been pushing the boundaries.

Backstage has been always out there when it comes to those big moments in Amsterdam. Example, the pride. I mean, one of the most interesting, exciting prides is the one you will have in

Amsterdam.

You also have Halloween, Amsterdam Dance Festival. Those are quite big themes in our city. And this is where you will always find Backstage somewhere in the backstage.

And this is what makes us always part of the conversation and makes us part of the dialogue. And this is where it's always exciting because you never have a dull moment at Backstage. There is always fun.

There is always excitement, joy. There is always time to create and time to empower and support and give back and contribute. So beside this, lately we have contributed also to the drag scene.

Beside us being one of the few places in Amsterdam that offer full on drag service in terms of hair and makeup, we have been sponsoring few of the mega balls in Amsterdam and it's been going really well. So this is also becoming one of the most interesting themes for us lately in Amsterdam. And I believe this is something that we will keep focusing on, keep pushing and it's all a part of our DNA here.

So I feel like those in my opinion are the most interesting themes and big moments in Amsterdam. Mo Garzu, the brand manager of Backstage Amsterdam. Mo, how can people find out more about Backstage online? Well, it's very simple.

Just go to our website, back-stage.nl. Check us out, check our Instagram. You will learn a lot about Backstage, what we do. You get a sense of the vibe and what you could expect.

And if you're ever coming to Amsterdam, just shoot us an email or a message and we'd love to show you around. And we could definitely plan a workshop together. We could host an event for you at Backstage or give you some makeovers.

Thank you so much, Mo. And thanks for being part of the program. That's so sweet of you, Jeff.

I was really honored to be part of your show. Thank you for the opportunity and thank you for introducing us to your community in Australia. That's so nice of you.

And really nice to meet you.